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FEATURES

ICE Is Trying to Avoid Oversight by Buying Private Prisons

Katya Schwenk · Jacobin

The Trump administration is considering purchasing a number of private immigrant detention centers across the US. Doing so may allow Immigration and Customs Enforcement to bypass state laws geared at curbing abuses in the facilities.

By buying facilities currently owned by private prison companies, ICE could help shield those detention centers from state oversight and some lawsuits tied to alleged abuse, including labor violations. (David McNew / Getty Images)

A White House plan to buy up private immigrant detention centers nationwide could be used to bypass state laws geared at curbing abuses amid President Donald Trump's immigration crackdown, insiders and experts tell the *Lever*.

Several of the detention centers reportedly short-listed for government takeover are located in the states that have been the most aggressive in their attempts to monitor and regulate private Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) detention facilities.

In February, internal documents first made public by New Hampshire state officials laid out in detail the Trump administration's ambitious plans for ICE's "new detention model," amid the agency's ongoing immigration crackdown. The documents proposed purchasing vacant industrial warehouses and transforming them into "mega" detention centers, an effort that has sparked significant public backlash.

But a second proposal in the document has largely flown under the radar: ICE's plan to purchase ten "turnkey facilities," private detention centers where its Enforcement and Removal Operations arm already operates.

By buying facilities currently owned by private prison companies, ICE could help shield those detention centers from state oversight and some lawsuits tied to alleged abuse, including labor violations.

In response to public pressure, states like California have passed laws that empower state officials to inspect private immigration detention centers. And in both Washington state and Colorado, ICE detainees who were forced to work for as little as a dollar a day at facilities owned by private prison giant GEO Group have sued for alleged violations of state labor laws.

But if the federal government owned these facilities outright, the Department of Homeland Security could try to claim additional legal immunity from many of these state restrictions, thanks to the broad immunity shield the federal government enjoys from lawsuits. How broad that immunity could ultimately extend will depend on the courts.

One source with direct knowledge of the calculus behind ICE's turnkey facility proposal confirmed to the *Lever* that additional legal immunity was seen as a potential benefit of the plan.

ICE did not return a request for comment.

"Hell-Bent on Exploiting Loopholes"

Though it appears ICE has not yet acted on its plans to purchase facilities from prison firms, a draft document obtained by the *Washington Post* indicated the agency is considering acquiring multiple facilities in California as well as facilities in Washington and Colorado.

All three of those states have laws on the books that target private ICE detention centers — and the GEO Group facilities in Washington and Colorado under consideration are currently embroiled in high-profile legal battles over state law violations.

Those cases have turned in part on whether privately owned detention centers should be treated as federal facilities under the law.

Anya Bidwell, a senior attorney at the public interest law firm Institute for Justice, which submitted an amicus brief this fall in one of the cases against GEO Group, said she believed ICE's intent to circumvent state laws by purchasing the facilities is "not just possible, but likely."

Bidwell noted that was especially true given that Trump's White House had proven to be "hell-bent on exploiting loopholes in the federal accountability regime."

"There are many immunity doctrines that are incentivizing the federal government to outright own the place," Bidwell said of ICE's proposal. "You don't have to leap too far to figure out why it is that they're doing that."

"There are many immunity doctrines that are incentivizing the federal government to outright own the place."

It would not be the Department of Homeland Security's only recent attempt to evade local accountability, as states and cities try to fight back against ICE operations in their neighborhoods.

As the grassroots research outfit Project Salt Box reported this month, ICE is employing a novel strategy to circumvent a recent New Mexico law banning state and local federal detention contracts. To dodge the ban, ICE has stopped contracting with county governments in the state and instead negotiated directly with the private prison firm CoreCivic.

Changing of the Guard

The Department of Homeland Security's sprawling detention apparatus has always relied heavily on private operators. Of the hundreds of facilities in which ICE detains immigrants, the agency owns vanishingly few outright.

The Number of Families Being Held at Dilley Detention Center Has Plummeted

Mica Rosenberg · ProPublica

The number of parents and children booked into the country's only immigrant family detention center, in Dilley, Texas, plummeted in February by more than 75% compared with a month earlier, according to Immigration and Customs Enforcement data obtained by ProPublica.

Between April 2025, when President Donald Trump started sending families there, and January of this year, the number of people sent into detention with their families averaged around 600 per month. In February, those so-called bookings fell to 133. As of mid-March, they dropped again to just 54.

This week there were only around 100 people in family detention at Dilley, compared with an average daily population in January of over 900, the data shows.

Current and former ICE officials and lawyers with clients in Dilley said they were unable to explain the reason for the sharp decline. However, they said the shift followed weeks of mounting public pressure generated in part by the widespread publication of letters written by several of the detained children in which they described the conditions inside Dilley and their despair at being ripped from their homes and schools.

ProPublica published several of those letters on Feb. 9 after visiting the facility — about an hour south of San Antonio — in mid-January. The letters set off a storm of outrage in Washington and across the country. They were raised in congressional hearings and pasted on posters in anti-ICE demonstrations.

Rep. James Walkinshaw, a Democrat from Virginia, read the letters aloud to ICE's acting director, Todd Lyons, during a congressional hearing on Feb. 10, pressing him for answers about whether the children's detention could cause adverse psychological effects. He pointed to one drawing by a 5-year-old Venezuelan girl named Luisanney Toloza of her family.

"My son's 5. He can't write many words, but he can communicate through drawings like this," Walkinshaw said, making special note of the expressions on the family's faces. "None of the faces are smiling."

It was another 5-year-old who first triggered public attention to children being detained at Dilley. Liam Conejo Ramos was picked up on Jan. 20 in Minnesota and sent to the facility with his father. A photograph of him at the time of his detention, wearing a blue bunny hat, went viral.

Detainees, emboldened by the attention, organized a protest in a yard at the facility that was captured in an aerial photograph and widely published on social media. Lawmakers demanded multiple visits to push for the release of Ramos and others. Nearly 4,000 doctors, nurses and health professionals sent a letter to the Trump admin-

istration calling for the immediate release of all children currently in immigration detention. This month, social media personality Rachel Accurso, an educator better known as Ms. Rachel, who makes popular children's programming, posted a video conversation with one of the kids detained at Dilley to her 4.9 million Instagram followers, garnering more than 3,700 comments.

Rep. Joaquin Castro, a Democrat from Texas, has been at the forefront of a push by legislators from his party to shut down Dilley and for the administration to find alternatives to family detentions. When told about the drop in the number of families being held at Dilley, he said, "That trailer prison is no place for children, and I'm glad to hear that the numbers continue to decline," adding, "It's a reminder that people can make a difference by speaking up."

The Department of Homeland Security, which oversees ICE, said in a statement that custody decisions are made "daily, on a case-by-case basis," adding that the "administration does not make immigration decisions based on public opinion. We follow the rule of law." In the past, the agency has said that Dilley offers families a safe environment equipped with access to educational materials, child care necessities and round-the-clock medical and mental health care. Meanwhile, CoreCivic, the private prison company operating the facility, said in a statement it does not have "any say whatsoever" in whether detainees are deported or released. In previous statements, it has said that the health and safety of detainees is its "top priority."

Dilley first opened as a family detention facility under former President Barack Obama in 2014, mostly for recent border crossers. Trump kept the facility running during his first term, but President Joe Biden stopped holding families in 2021, arguing the United States shouldn't be in the business of detaining children.

Soon after taking office a second time, Trump resumed family detentions at Dilley. As border crossings have dropped to record lows, more of the families being held there have been arrested inside the United States and have been in the country long enough to lay down roots and build networks of relatives and friends. The children detained there have ranged in age from newborns to older teenagers. The vast majority of adults held at Dilley had no U. S. criminal record.

Following the protests and the publication of children's letters, detainees and attorneys interviewed by ProPublica said guards took away crayons, colored pencils and drawing paper during recent room searches. This week, ProPublica learned the facility had cut off access to video calls in common areas.

The Trump administration said in a recent court filing that personal property had not been destroyed at Dilley and items confiscated during searches were "limited to materials identified as protest-related and not authorized under facility rules." CoreCivic "vehemently" denied staff confiscated or destroyed children's personal artwork or supplies.

Pytest parameter functions

Ned Batchelder

Pytest's `parametrize` is a great feature for writing tests without repeating yourself needlessly. (If you haven't seen it before, read [Starting with pytest's parametrize first](#)). When the data gets complex, it can help to use functions to build the data parameters.

I've been working on a project involving multi-line data, and the parameterized test data was getting awkward to create and maintain. I created helper functions to make it nicer. The actual project is a bit gnarly, so I'll use a simpler example to demonstrate.

Here's a function that takes a multi-line string and returns two numbers, the lengths of the shortest and longest non-blank lines:

```
"""Stats of non-blank lines: shortest and longest lengths."""
lengths = [len(ln) for ln in text.splitlines() if ln]
return min(lengths), max(lengths)
```

We can test it with a simple parameterized test with two test cases:

```
import pytest

from non_blanks import non_blanks

@pytest.mark.parametrize(
    "text, short, long",
    [
        ("abcde\n a\n abc\n", 1, 5),
        ("""
A long line

The next line is blank:

Short.

Much much longer line, more than anyone thought.
""", 6, 48),
    ]
)

def test_non_blanks(text, short, long):
    assert non_blanks(text) == (short, long)
```

I really dislike how the multi-line string breaks the indentation flow, so I wrap strings like that in `textwrap.dedent`:

```
@pytest.mark.parametrize(
    "text, short, long",
    [
        ("abcde\n a\n abc\n", 1, 5),
        (textwrap.dedent("""
A long line

The next line is blank:

Short.

Much much longer line, more than anyone thought.
"""),
        6, 48),
    ]
)

(
    Path("gettysburg.txt").read_text(), 18, 80),
```

New Footage Shows Wanted Kinahan Cartel Kingpins Post-Sanctions

Financial Investigations Team · Bellingcat

This article is the result of a collaboration with The Sunday Times. You can find their corresponding piece here .

Daniel and Christy Kinahan at a Dubai sports arena last June. Source: WeCaptureYou, TrillerTV

Kinahan cartel leaders Daniel and Christy Kinahan have been photographed in Dubai, marking the most recent sighting of the wanted crime bosses since the US government put multi-million dollar bounties on their heads.

The footage was captured just weeks after Kinahan cartel lieutenant Sean McGovern was extradited from the United Arab Emirates (UAE) to Ireland, where he was charged with murder and directing the activities of a criminal organisation.

Filed during a mixed martial arts (MMA) event in June, the images are the first visual proof that the drug cartel's leadership — who fled from Spain to Dubai in 2016 — were still in hiding in the desert city as recently as last summer.

Wanted posters for Irish drugs smugglers Daniel, Christy and Christopher Kinahan Jr. Sanctions were imposed on the Kinahan cartel in 2022, prohibiting financial institutions and businesses from dealing with the family, their associates and companies. Source: US Department of the Treasury

Christy Kinahan, 68, and his two sons, Daniel, 48, and Christopher Jr, 45 — the most senior members of the Kinahan Organised Crime Group — are wanted by authorities around the world. The three Irishmen have been sanctioned by the US government and are the subject of a collective \$15 million reward for information leading to their arrest.

Bellingcat and The Sunday Times have previously revealed how Christy Kinahan left a trail of Google reviews exposing his movements and travel partners over a five year period. We also uncovered the gang's links to a German businessman charged with trafficking cocaine in 2024, and to an Australian pilot who was killed during a failed drug run in South America last year.

“Google Gangster” Christy Kinahan has posted hundreds of reviews online, rating everything from luxury hotels to a Covid-19 test centre.

Bellingcat discovered this new footage of the narco-traffickers after running a photo posted to social media of one of Daniel Kinahan's adult sons — whose name was published last year — through face recognition search engine PimEyes.

It returned a professional photograph of Daniel Kinahan that was taken during the 971 Fighting Championship (971 FC) at the Coca-Cola Arena in Dubai's City Walk district on June 14, 2025.

Pictured wearing a black top, baseball cap and glasses, he is sitting ringside next to the event's founder and former Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC) athlete, Mounir “The Sniper” Lazzez .

Daniel Kinahan (left) watches a fight with Mounir Lazzez at the 971 FC in Dubai last year (image cropped by Bellingcat). Lazzez has been an outspoken supporter of Kinahan. Source: WeCaptureYou

(The image, which had been posted to a Dubai photography company's website, was removed yesterday, hours after Bellingcat contacted a representative for the Kinahans to seek comment.)

A frame-by-frame sweep of official footage and user-generated content from the arena revealed that Christy Kinahan, the founder of the eponymous drug cartel, was also among the reported 6,000 spectators at the fight night.

Left: The shot of Christy Kinahan discovered by Bellingcat in a YouTube clip posted by event organiser 971 FC (edits applied by Bellingcat in Adobe Lightroom: image has been sharpened, and contrast, exposure and clarity increased). Right: A full-length shot of Kinahan, visible in the footage live-streamed to TrillerTV.

The elusive crime boss — nicknamed “The Dapper Don” — is seen wearing a Panama hat, blue Polo shirt, white trousers and blue trainers.

These images of the cartel leaders are the first to emerge since Bellingcat published the most recent known photograph of Christopher Kinahan Jr in 2024, captured during a meeting with his father in a Dubai restaurant the year before.

Christopher Kinahan Jr and his father Christy Kinahan, seen in the background of a photo posted to a Dubai restaurant's social media, in 2023. The Kinahans fled from their base on Spain's Costa Del Sol to Dubai in late 2016, in the wake of a deadly feud with the rival Hutch gang.

The new footage of Daniel Kinahan marks the first time he has been pictured since the US government levied sanctions on the transnational organised crime group in April 2022.

The Man in the Panama Hat

The Kinahan cartel is one the world's most notorious criminal organisations. Worth an estimated €1.5 billion, it is involved in drug trafficking, arms smuggling and money laundering operations around the world. Investigators have also linked the gang to Iran's intelligence services and the Lebanon-based Islamic militant group Hezbollah.

It was reportedly part of a “Super Cartel”, a criminal network that controlled much of Europe's cocaine trade. Five of the network's key members have been arrested since 2017, but one — Daniel Kinahan — remains at large.

Daniel Kinahan, who authorities say is responsible for

An OB-GYN Was Repeatedly Accused of Sexual Misconduct. The State Medical Board Let Him Keep Practicing.

Ashley Hiruko · ProPublica

The woman, 52, lay on the exam table at a clinic in Richland, Washington. Her legs were parted and propped up.

The OB-GYN, Dr. Mark Mulholland, stood between her legs, inquiring about the woman's sex life as he had in prior visits, she wrote in a complaint filed with Washington state health care regulators.

She said Mulholland had previously asked about her enjoyment of sex and if she had a boyfriend, a strange way to learn about a patient's sexual activity, she thought. But this was her last checkup after her hysterectomy and the last time she expected to see Mulholland.

"Do you masturbate?" Mulholland asked the woman during their final appointment, according to her complaint.

The question shocked her. She wrote that Mulholland explained he wanted to "make sure the nerves were intact."

Then, the woman wrote, he inserted his fingers into her vagina and pumped his hand back and forth in a way she said felt "sexual and not medical."

"Does that hurt?" the woman said Mulholland asked her, before ending their visit by saying "the playroom is open" — a comment she interpreted as Mulholland clearing her for sexual activity.

The woman said she left the room in shock. She made her way to the parking lot of the Kadlec Clinic-Associated Physicians for Women, climbed inside her car and sat, incredulous, she said in an interview with KUOW and ProPublica. What happened felt terribly wrong, she said.

Mulholland did not respond to requests for comment for this article after being sent a detailed list of findings by email and by letter. His attorney declined to comment.

What the woman didn't know was that by the time of her exam in February 2025, the Washington Medical Commission had already received complaints from four other women since 2022 accusing Mulholland of sexual misconduct. And yet he was allowed to keep seeing patients throughout.

The accounts related by the women, whom KUOW and ProPublica are not naming to protect their privacy, included descriptions of Mulholland touching them unnecessarily, using sexually charged language, or performing painful or seemingly sexual pelvic exams that involved moving his fingers in and out.

The commission also gathered testimony a year before the woman's February 2025 appointment from three of Mulholland's colleagues with their own troubling accounts. These included hearing firsthand about or observing him

telling patients they had "tight" and "pretty" vaginas, touching and slapping his patients' legs, and aggressively pulling a patient's pants down without permission.

Washington law allows the commission to take emergency action and suspend a doctor's license while disciplinary proceedings are pending. The law says a suspension is defensible if it's more probable than not that the physician poses an "immediate threat to the public health and safety."

In Mulholland's case, the commission did not choose suspension. Instead, it issued a formal statement of charges accusing Mulholland of abuse and unprofessional conduct in April 2025 — more than a year after the commission's investigator submitted her reports on two of the complaints for review and 11 months after Mulholland was offered an informal settlement that he apparently did not sign.

Even after the commission declared its charges against Mulholland, he was allowed to keep practicing while the case proceeded. He saw patients as late as May, before he went on leave.

At least 84 patients have filed lawsuits against Mulholland or his employer since the state's investigation became public. Court filings by Mulholland's attorney, made in response to the lawsuits, have denied wrongdoing or improper conduct toward women. He also has denied the allegations made by the medical commission and is entitled to a hearing to contest them.

Emily Volland, a spokesperson for Kadlec and its affiliate, the Providence health system, said Mulholland is no longer employed by Kadlec. Volland declined to comment on the allegations against him but said via email: "We take our patient's safety very seriously and are fully cooperating with the state in this matter."

The lawsuits against Mulholland, Kadlec and Providence are ongoing. Lawyers for Providence and Kadlec in court filings denied allegations of negligence and wrongdoing.

While other news coverage has described the lawsuits and the commission's actions in 2025, none has focused on how the state dealt with complaints against Mulholland during the three years before he agreed to restrictions on his license.

Washington state has faced criticism in the past for its handling of sexual misconduct complaints. A 2021 Seattle Times investigation found that in 282 cases of alleged sexual misconduct since 2009, state regulators took more than a year to impose discipline.

Several other states in recent years have dealt with their own high-profile cases of sexual misconduct involving OB-GYNs. On March 10, for instance, Columbia University in New York released a report detailing how a culture of silence at the institution had allowed OB-GYN Robert Hadden to abuse more than 1,000 patients over decades.

Munition Remnants Pictured at Site of Deadly Chad Strike Match Weapon Previously Used by Sudan's RSF

Sebastian Vandermeersch · Bellingcat

Munition remnants pictured at the site of a strike that killed at least 17 people in the town of Tiné, Chad, last week appear to match a weapon previously used by Sudan's Rapid Support Forces (RSF) in the war with Sudanese government forces – despite RSF denials of involvement in the incident.

Photographs showed what appeared to be a match for the rear control section of a Chinese-made GB25A or GB50A bomb, which can be dropped by Chinese-made drones. Amnesty International previously identified a GB50A used by the RSF that it said had “almost certainly” been re-exported to the group by the UAE.

Remnants of a Chinese-made GB25A or GB50A bomb pictured in Tiné, Chad (left). A reference image showing GB25A and GB50A bombs.

A separate set of photographs showing even clearer visuals of the remnants were subsequently shared by the N'Djamena-based broadcaster MRTV. Its Facebook page showed Chadian soldiers standing beside the remnants.

Images were also posted by posted on Facebook by the Department of Public Safety and Immigration in Chad.

By using the time displayed on a watch worn by an official in one of the pictures it was possible to estimate that the images were likely taken in the late afternoon. By comparing this with solar data, the shadows visible in the photos and other visual details, it was then possible to infer the approximate layout of nearby buildings and the distribution of trees where the remnants were found.

Picture featuring Ali Ahmat Aghabache, Chad Minister of Public Security and Immigration. The time on his watch was used as an approximate time of capture of the set of images at the remnant site. Credit: Ministère De La Sécurité Publique Et De L'immigration Facebook.

With this information, and using satellite imagery, we then geolocated the photos to the northwest of the Bir Tine neighbourhood, just 650 metres from the border with the Western Darfur region of Sudan that is largely controlled by the RSF.

Top: Using the approximate time of capture, Bellingcat analyzed solar data to reconstruct the site layout and created an approximate panoramic view. Bottom: This reconstruction enabled the identification of building features and tree positions, leading to the precise determination of the site's coordinates. (15.043158, 22.818438)

Remnants from the control sections of other GB25A or GB50A bombs have previously been found after RSF attacks in Sudan, including attacks on Kassala Airport and Coral Marina Hotel in Port Sudan (as seen in the images below).

Still frames of remnants found in Tiné, Chad (left), Kassala Airport, Sudan (centre) and Coral Marina Hotel Sudan (right).

BBC News reported that the RSF is suspected of carrying out the attack.

However, the RSF has denied any involvement and blamed Sudan's army, the Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF). The SAF has in turn said the RSF was responsible. Chad's president on Thursday ordered the military to retaliate against future attacks from Sudan.

Your donations directly contribute to our ability to publish groundbreaking investigations and uncover wrongdoing around the world.

RSF spokesperson Al-Fateh Qurashi told Bellingcat via WhatsApp: “Our forces are not responsible for any targeting of neighboring Chad, and we have no connection to this targeting.” Qurashi instead blamed forces aligned with the Sudanese government over the strike.

Imran Abdullah, an adviser to the RSF commander, told Bellingcat via WhatsApp that satellite imagery tracked the drone and that it belonged to the forces aligned with the Sudanese government. However, Abdullah refused to share the imagery he referred to saying: “It can be published if an independent international commission of inquiry is in place.”

The SAF are not known to use any Chinese-made drones or bombs, like the GB25A or GB50A. The SAF has been observed using Turkish and Iranian made drones and munitions such as the MAM-L bomb.

Bellingcat sought comment on the use of these weapons from the Chinese manufacturer, Norinco, as well as the UAE given Amnesty's previous reports about how a GB50A was used by the RSF after “almost certainly” being re-exported to Sudan. Neither responded prior to publication.

The conflict has previously spilled over the border into Chad. Reuters reported last month the country closed its border with Sudan after five Chadian soldiers were killed following clashes in Tiné between the RSF and militia fighters loyal to the Sudanese government.

Ziyu Wan and Riccardo Giannardi contributed from Bellingcat's volunteer community.

The post Munition Remnants Pictured at Site of Deadly Chad Strike Match Weapon Previously Used by Sudan's RSF appeared first on [bellingcat](#).

Electronic Frontier Foundation to swap leaders as AI, ICE fights escalate

Ashley Belanger · Ars Technica Policy

Back in 2022 when Cindy Cohn, the executive director of a US digital rights nonprofit called the Electronic Frontier Foundation, started writing her memoir, *Privacy's Defender*, she worried that people would think she was an “old fuddy duddy” still sounding alarms about government spying online.

As one of EFF's first litigators and then its long-time leader, Cohn witnessed firsthand how government surveillance became one of the earliest concerns for civil rights advocates when the Internet became mainstream in the 1990s. Since then, attention has pivoted away from caring about government's Internet abuses to focusing much more on Big Tech harms, she said.

But then Donald Trump's second term started, launching aggressive Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) operations nationwide that depended on abusing tech to support its goals of mass deportation. Railing against ICE raids, communities have quickly mobilized to defend online privacy, even banding together across political divides to tear down Flock cameras that can aid in arrests. Maybe even more concerning, as the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) has increasingly sought to unmask ICE critics on social media—and largely failed —EFF has filed and backed lawsuits fighting to protect Americans' rights to track ICE activity and share information anonymously online.

[Read full article](#)

Meta loses trial after arguing child exploitation was “inevitable” on its apps

Ashley Belanger · Ars Technica Policy

Meta has lost the first of three child safety trials it's facing this year after a jury in a New Mexico state court found that the social media giant's platforms do not effectively protect kids from child exploitation.

On Tuesday, the jury deliberated for only one day before agreeing that Meta should pay \$375 million in civil damages for violating state consumer protections and misleading parents about the safety of its apps.

The trial followed a 2023 lawsuit filed by New Mexico Attorney General Raúl Torrez after The Guardian published a two-year investigation exposing child sex trafficking markets on Facebook and Instagram. Torrez's office then conducted an undercover investigation codenamed “Operation MetaPhile,” in which officers posed as children on Facebook, Instagram, and WhatsApp. The jury heard that these fake profiles were “simply inundated with images and targeted solicitations” from child abusers, Torrez told CNBC in 2024. Ultimately, three men were arrested amid the sting for attempting to use Meta's social networks to prey on children.

[Read full article](#)

Since then, attention has pivoted away from caring about government's Internet abuses to focusing much more on Big Tech harms, she said.

Ashley Belanger

DOJ confirms FBI Director Kash Patel's personal email was hacked

Ashley Belanger · Ars Technica Policy

Iran-linked hackers successfully broke into FBI Director Kash Patel's personal email, the Department of Justice confirmed to Reuters on Friday.

Reuters could not authenticate the leaked emails themselves but noted that the Gmail address matched an email account "linked to Patel in previous data breaches preserved by the dark web intelligence firm District 4 Labs." The DOJ suggested the emails appeared to be authentic.

On their website, the Handala Hack Team boasted that Patel "will now find his name among the list of successfully hacked victims." The hacker group taunted Patel by sharing photos of him sniffing cigars and holding up a jug of rum, along with other documents that Reuters reported were from 2010 to 2019.

[Read full article](#)

This Weekend's No Kings Rallies Were Historically Massive

Alex Nguyen · Mother Jones

On Saturday millions of people around the country took part in more than 3,000 No Kings protests opposing the presidency of Donald Trump, whose approval ratings have plummeted to 36 percent, a record low since his return to the White House.

Saturday's rallies were the third major No Kings protest, with organizers saying that 8 million people took part. That estimate has not been independently verified. But to put this weekend's anti-Trump protests in perspective: about 300,000 people attended the April 2009 Tea Party protests against the Obama administration that were heralded as a seismic political event.

My Mother Jones colleagues were on the ground yesterday covering the action around the country:

St. Petersburg, Florida

Washington, D. C.

St. Paul, Minnesota

Oakland, California

Given the immense outpouring, what could these demonstrations mean for future organizing?

According to Payday Report, an outlet that covers labor and union news, Indivisible, one of the lead organizers of the No Kings protests, is backing the May Day Strong coalition, which is calling for "No Work, No School, No Shopping" on May 1.

Leah Greenberg, the co-founder of Indivisible, said, "On May 1, Indivisibles will be joining people across the country with a clear message: we demand a government that invests in our communities, not one that enriches billionaires, fuels endless war, or deploys masked agents to intimidate our neighbors."

What Are The Swing States Of The Future?

Amelia Thomson-DeVeaux · FiveThirtyEight

2024 Election

What Are The Swing States Of The Future?

A FiveThirtyEight Chat

Sep. 6, 2023, at 10:45 AM

Welcome to FiveThirtyEight's politics chat . The transcript below has been lightly edited.

ameliatd (Amelia Thomson-DeVeaux , senior reporter): The residents of states like Pennsylvania, Wisconsin and Michigan are used to having their airwaves flooded with political ads as presidential elections draw near. But over the years, there's actually been a lot of variation in which states have the most power to decide the future commander-in-chief. Only a few years ago, it would have been hard to imagine Arizona and Georgia in the toss-up category — and “as Ohio goes, so goes the nation” was proved wrong in 2020 , when President Joe Biden became the first candidate to win the White House without carrying Ohio since 1960.

So have Arizona and Georgia replaced Ohio as the nation's presidential bellwether? Is once-swingy Florida officially a red state ? Let's talk about what are the swing states to watch in 2024 — and what are the states that could be toss-ups just a few election cycles from now.

First question — admittedly it's still early (come with your ðŸ™¥ takes, I give you permission to change your mind later), but what do you think are the most underrated potential swing states for the 2024 cycle?

nrakich (Nathaniel Rakich , senior elections analyst) : I think an underrated swing state is Florida. People have written it off after it swung unexpectedly to Republicans in 2020 and after Sen. Marco Rubio and Gov. Ron DeSantis won reelection by almost 20 percentage points in 2022. But people forget that former President Donald Trump won it in 2020 by only 3 points.

If the 2024 election is shaping up to be a rematch between Trump and Biden, I think it's reasonable to think Florida could be tight again. Do I think Biden will win it? No, probably not. But I think it's still a better investment for Biden's campaign dollars than, say, Texas.

gelliottmorris (G. Elliott Morris , editorial director of data analytics): I agree with you on Florida, Nathaniel — but for a separate reason. Right now the conventional wisdom is that a 2024 rematch between Biden and Trump would be closer than in 2020: Polls have the two candidates roughly tied in the national popular vote. But given Trump's legal troubles, I think there's a decent chance that polls will move in the opposite direction over the next year, assuming the two candidates both stay in the race, with Biden polling at or better than his 2020 levels. And if that were to happen,

Florida would naturally be even closer to the 50-50 line just by virtue of the national political environment moving more to the left.

nrakich: Interesting, Elliott — so basically you're saying you don't think Florida will be the tipping-point state , but depending on the national environment you think it could be competitive?

gelliottmorris : Yeah, that's right. For a similar reason, I think people are too quick to count out blue-ish states like New Hampshire and Minnesota as swing states. The partisan lean of both states is only around 3 points toward Democrats. If the political environment moves toward Republicans, they are potentially up for grabs for Trump. It's easy to see how further degradation with the white working class could flip one or both of them, for example.

nrakich: Strongly agreed on Minnesota. It feels like people have already forgotten how shocked they were in 2016 when the “blue wall” states of Michigan, Wisconsin and Pennsylvania flipped to Republicans. That could easily happen again with Minnesota the next time Republicans have a strong national election.

Minnesota currently has the longest streak of voting for one party's presidential candidate of any state in the nation — it hasn't voted for a Republican since Richard Nixon in 1972. But that streak has concealed some close calls over that period, so I think Democrats are a bit complacent about their standing in the Gopher State.

geoffrey.skelley (Geoffrey Skelley , senior elections analyst) : I think a lot of this comes down to how you define a swing state. I tend to think about one larger group of battleground states that, under a set of realistic but more favorable conditions, could flip to one party. Then you have a smaller group of core swing states that are actually most likely to decide the outcome of the election.

We've mentioned a bunch of states from my larger list so far, so I'll mention a place that's in my core group of swing areas but isn't a state: Nebraska's 2nd Congressional District. Under the new congressional lines, Biden carried it by a little more than 6 percentage points in 2020, not far from his 4.5-point national win. But under a number of scenarios , that one little electoral vote from the Omaha-based seat could play a role in bringing about — or avoiding — a 269-269 tie in the Electoral College. To me, that makes it underrated.

ameliatd: That's an interesting question, Geoffrey — does some of this come down to how you define a swing state? What do you think, Nathaniel and Elliott?

nrakich: Yeah, I would define “swing state” closer to “tipping-point state” — i.e., a state (or district!) that could decide the election. If you define it simply as a competitive state, almost any state could be a swing state under the right circumstances. It's hard to imagine right now, but it's possible that, in 2036 or something, a Democrat or Republican will win the national popular vote by some massive margin and

They once called him a ‘goose-stepping extremist.’ They’re now sitting out his comeback bid.

By Samuel Benson and Alec Hernandez · Politico

When Brandon Herrera ran for Congress in 2024, the Republican Jewish Coalition called him “a goose-stepping extremist” and spent big to take him down. Two years later, he’s the presumptive GOP nominee — and his former foes are staying home as the GOP establishment moves to embrace him.

Herrera, a gun shop owner and popular YouTuber known as “The AKGuy” running in Texas’ 23rd Congressional District, has faced widespread criticism for past videos in which he mimics a Nazi march to Nazi music, jokes about the Holocaust and boasts about his 1939 edition of “Mein Kampf.” His 2024 opponent, Rep. Tony Gonzales (R-Texas) called him a “known neo-Nazi,” a characterization Herrera disputes. Concern over Herrera’s comments were so severe that the American Israel Public Affairs Committee’s United Democracy Project spent more than \$1 million two years ago and the Republican Jewish Coalition spent close to \$400,000 to sink his campaign.

But now, a scandal forced Gonzales to drop out of the runoff, and Herrera is the GOP nominee in the sprawling, GOP-leaning Texas border district, which President Donald Trump carried by a 17-point margin in 2024.

And faced with the choice of a candidate they’ve long accused of antisemitism and a Democrat, these pro-Israel and Jewish groups are thus far choosing to sit on their hands.

AIPAC, which backs both Democratic and Republican pro-Israel candidates and usually focuses its efforts in primaries, has not endorsed in the race. AIPAC spokesperson Deryn Sousa said in a statement only that the group would “continue to assess where candidates across the country stand on issues that affect the U. S.-Israel partnership.”

And the RJC, which only supports Republican candidates, won’t get involved. “The RJC has a longstanding policy of speaking out against those who traffic in Nazi ideology, and this is another case,” said RJC political director and spokesperson Sam Markstein. “The RJC opposed Mr. Herrera in 2024, and he will not get our support now.”

But Markstein made clear it was likely they would sit the race out rather than oppose him in the general election. “We’ve never supported a Democrat, so that should tell you everything you need to know,” he said.

In the weeks since Herrera finished as the top vote-getter in Texas’ March 4 primary and Gonzales dropped out, the GOP establishment has largely embraced Herrera.

Last week, as lawmakers and donors socialized during a glitzy Mar-a-Lago fundraiser for the House Freedom Caucus, which backed him in the primary, Herrera made a triumphant appearance, according to an attendee granted

anonymity to detail a private event and another attendee’s post on social media. Trump announced his endorsement on social media the same night.

“Brandon is strongly supported by many Highly Respected MAGA Warriors in Texas, and Republicans in the US House,” Trump wrote. “HE WILL NEVER LET YOU DOWN!”

Speaker Mike Johnson and House GOP leadership followed a week later, calling him an “America First grassroots leader” in a joint statement Thursday.

Trump’s endorsement brings “a little bit of comfort” to pro-Israel GOP donors who view Trump as a loyal ally, said Gabriel Groisman, a Florida-based GOP donor active in pro-Israel circles. “We trust the president and his team in their vetting of congressional candidates,” Groisman said. “But it doesn’t mean we don’t ask questions and we don’t dig further.” And Groisman said that the “ugly truth about politics” is Jewish Republican donors are now faced with the option of him or a Democrat, rather than another Republican. “So the question is whether it’s better to have him in [office], or not. That’s a very, very difficult question to answer.”

Herrera criticized AIPAC’s spending against him in 2024, calling it “Israel first bullshit.” “I’m not anti-Israel, I’m anti Israel buying American elections,” he wrote on social media.

He has also been critical of U. S. policy toward Israel, arguing American taxpayers should not have to pay for military aid to Israel. We shouldn’t be spending a cent of taxpayer dollars on anything that is not either an investment or right here in the United States,” he said in a speech, Israel National News reported. “I don’t hate my neighbor just because I don’t want to pay his power bill. If they want to buy rockets from us, let’s sell to them.”

Republicans’ embrace of Herrera shows how seriously the GOP values maintaining control of the House this cycle, even as some Republicans warn of growing antisemitism within their own ranks.

Herrera’s campaign has continued to publicly push back on criticisms of his social media history, which they contend are taken out of context from his “work as a historical firearms educator” and omitting extended clips that include “comments ridiculing and condemning Hitler’s book.”

“The accusations against Brandon were bizarre and false, manufactured by a desperate political opponent who misleadingly cut and pasted together disparate video clips,” Herrera campaign manager Kimmie Gonzalez said in a statement.

Groisman, the Florida-based donor, said Herrera’s allies are working to assuage concerns about his past statements through outreach to Jewish and pro-Israel donors in Texas and beyond.

AIPAC faces calls to reassess strategy after split results in Illinois

By Lisa Kashinsky and Elena Schneider · Politico

The American Israel Public Affairs Committee saw mixed results in the first major test of its political muscle in the midterms, drawing fresh recriminations from its foes — and some allies — for its interference in four competitive Illinois House primaries.

Two of AIPAC's supported candidates won their races Tuesday night, with Cook County Commissioner Donna Miller denying former Rep. Jesse Jackson Jr. a comeback in the 2nd District and former Rep. Melissa Bean defeating a slew of progressive challengers in the 8th District.

But the group faced criticism from within the pro-Israel Democratic community and harsh words from its opponents after it failed to secure its preferred outcome in the two races where it spent the most money.

In the 9th District, the group spent \$7 million, some of it aimed at attacking Evanston Mayor Daniel Biss, whose mother is Israeli, making an enemy of a likely soon-to-be U. S. representative who has been critical of Israel's actions in Gaza but who had previously been willing to engage with the group. Biss won the crowded primary Tuesday night, after AIPAC pivoted from attacking him to instead concentrate its negative ads on progressive social media influencer and Palestinian American Kat Abughazaleh. And in the 7th District, an AIPAC-affiliated super PAC spent nearly \$5 million backing Chicago Treasurer Melissa Conyears-Ervin, who lost to state Rep. La Shawn Ford.

The split scorecard comes a month after AIPAC angered its own centrist allies by going after another fairly pro-Israel candidate, former Rep. Tom Malinowski (D-N. J.) — a move that ended up handing the primary to a stronger critic of Israel, progressive Analilia Mejia.

"There was once again a vast amount of money spent and wasted trying to dust up a candidate who, by almost anybody's reasonable analysis, Israel should be happy to have in Congress supporting a strong U. S.-Israel relationship," one longtime AIPAC member, granted anonymity to speak candidly, said of the group's spending against Biss.

AIPAC, the person added, "should take a look at the results in [the 9th District] and New Jersey and reconsider their strategy."

AIPAC-aligned super PACs spent nearly \$22 million in the Illinois primaries, more than one-fifth the total \$100 million war chest it has in hand so far for the 2026 midterms, to win two of four open-seat races while losing the one that drew the most national attention.

At his victory party Tuesday night, Biss slammed the group for spending heavily "to buy this seat to support the idea that we can't accept nuance" on the U. S.-Israel relationship.

"AIPAC found out the hard way — the 9th District is not for sale," Biss told supporters.

AIPAC pushed back against the notion that the group struggled in Tuesday night's elections.

"Illinois voters rejected half a dozen anti-Israel candidates across several heavily Democratic open-seat races," Deryn Sousa, an AIPAC spokesperson, said in a statement Tuesday night. "These results further demonstrate that campaigns defined largely by opposition to AIPAC, our members, and the values we represent continue to fall short on election night."

The controversial organization, already a foil for Democrats grappling with growing anti-Israel sentiment in their party, is facing fresh animosity and renewed scrutiny over its campaign spending as the U. S. and Israel wage a joint war on Iran that's further soured Americans on their longtime ally.

Recent polling shows Americans — and Democrats, in particular — shifting further away from Israel. A NBC News poll released this week showed 57 percent of Democrats view Israel negatively, a dramatic shift from when just 35 percent held a negative view of the country after Hamas attacked it on Oct. 7, 2023. A Quinnipiac University survey showed 44 percent of voters think the U. S. is too supportive of Israel — the highest percentage since the pollsters started asking the question in 2017. Among Democrats, 62 percent think America is too supportive of Israel, compared with just 22 percent who think the support is about right and 8 percent who think it's not supportive enough.

It's clear the organization is aware of its standing in Democratic primaries — its ads focused on everything but Israel, accusing candidates of not being progressive enough on other issues. But AIPAC's involvement became a major talking point for those it was attacking, especially in the 9th District.

The Illinois Democratic delegation likely won't have a significant ideological shift on Israel from the races' results. Bean will replace Rep. Raja Krishnamoorthi, another pro-Israel candidate, who lost his Senate primary contest to Illinois Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton. Biss's views on Israel aren't far from those of outgoing Rep. Jan Schakowsky, who endorsed him and has sharply criticized AIPAC in the past. Rep. Danny Davis has supported Israel but denounced its Gaza intervention; Ford has refused to commit to unconditional aid to Israel.

The biggest potential change is Miller replacing Rep. Robin Kelly, who has called the war in Gaza a "genocide." She also didn't advance through the Illinois Senate primary.

"We consider this a pro-Israel win. We are better off in the Chicago delegation than we were yesterday," said Patrick Dorton, the spokesperson for the AIPAC super PAC United Democracy Project, pointing to the new incumbents in the Kelly, Schakowsky and Davis seats.

Donald Trump Is Unpopular. That Only Matters in a Democracy.

Ben Beckett · Jacobin

US democracy has been degrading for years. Donald Trump has the motive, the disposition, and the political and legal infrastructure to simply circumvent it, especially with such low approval ratings and midterm elections around the corner.

Donald Trump is deeply unpopular and convinced he can only lose through fraud. Now he's seeking direct control over elections, while ICE has demonstrated that it will act as his personal paramilitary force. (Chip Somodevilla / Getty Images)

Donald Trump is incredibly unpopular. His approval rating across multiple polls is well below 40 percent. Fifty percent of respondents say his actions in office have been worse than expected, while only 27 percent support "all or most" of his policies, according to a January Pew Research Center poll. A sampling of polls from February and March found that on average, 58 percent of respondents disapprove of Trump's handling of the economy. In a separate poll, 59 percent said the economy is getting worse.

Even his standout issues are looking lackluster. Traditionally he has polled better on immigration than on other issues, but following the various "surges" of immigration enforcement that acted as de facto paramilitary occupations of cities like Minneapolis and Chicago, 49 percent of poll respondents say they "strongly disapprove" of Trump's handling of immigration. Half of respondents, including a majority of self-described independents, now support abolishing Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) entirely.

Presidents typically enjoy broad support for military actions. An embarrassingly high number of Americans — 40 percent, per CBS — support the US war on Iran, but this figure is still significantly lower than support for past major military conflicts. Just 7 percent of adults support sending ground troops into Iran, a prospect that seems increasingly likely. (A majority of Republican poll respondents support sending "special forces" troops but not a general invasion.) In contrast, CBS found that 92 percent of Americans say the top priority should be ending the conflict as quickly as possible, and 68 percent say Trump has not clearly explained the United States' goals in attacking Iran.

Trump's war of choice on Iran has already sent gas prices soaring 32 percent higher than before the attack, with no end in sight for rises in the price of oil. As the conflict drags on, the cost of oil will have an exponential effect on the prices of other goods as well. Perhaps most immediately, the war has delayed the delivery and dramatically increased the price of fertilizer in the United States and Asia. This will almost certainly have a major impact on farmers' bottom lines as well as costs at the grocery store, which the US Department of Agriculture was already predicting would rise

faster this year than in 2024 or 2025 before Trump attacked Iran.

While it is still early in the election cycle, prospects for Democrats regaining control of the House of Representatives currently look fairly strong. It is difficult to imagine that any of the policies Trump is pursuing will make Republicans more popular before November. Winning a majority in the House would not allow Democrats to pass much of their own agenda, but it would give them greater leverage in budget negotiations and greater power to subpoena members of Trump's government, allow them to release more of the Jeffrey Epstein files, and raise the prospect once again of filing articles of impeachment — even though the Senate is extremely unlikely to come to a guilty verdict.

Trump, obviously, does not want any of these things to happen. Two critical questions for the next seven months are how far Trump and Republicans are willing to go to ensure the GOP remains in full control of Congress, and whether there is anyone in a position to stop them. On both counts, there is cause for concern.

Popularity Only Matters in a Democracy

For years, Trump has insisted that he lost the 2020 election only due to voter fraud. The fact that every investigation has found these claims unsubstantiated has not deterred him from nursing this grievance. Neither has the fact that he won the 2024 election. If there was indeed a great conspiracy to keep him out of office that was successful in 2020, it's unclear why it would have failed in 2024. But far be it from Trump to hold his grandiose persecution fantasies to a standard of logical coherence.

In response, Trump and congressional Republicans have continued the Right's decades-long project of making it more difficult to vote. This year, they have been pushing hard to pass the Safeguard American Voter Eligibility (SAVE) Act into law. If passed, the act would impose extreme new identification requirements both to register to vote and to actually cast a ballot. The bill is currently under filibuster in the Senate and so the exact requirements are not set, but if it became law, the act would require some combination of a passport, an official birth certificate, and additional identification both to register and each time a person voted. It would also increase the frequency with which states are required to purge their voter rolls. And just this week, oral arguments at the Supreme Court suggest that justices in the conservative court majority were open to significantly restricting mail-in voting.

Republicans are now clearly establishing the tools, rhetorical and practical, to allow law enforcement to insert itself into elections in a manner without recent precedent and guaranteed to favor their party.

The Trump administration is portraying the SAVE Act as an election integrity measure, but make no mistake: its purpose is to suppress the vote among legitimate eligible voters. The SAVE Act is an extreme version of the Right's

Evidence Points to US Scattering Mines over Iranian Village

Trevor Ball · Bellingcat

The US appears to have deployed the Gator Scatterable Mine system over Kafari, a village near Shiraz, in southern Iran overnight. Several people were killed according to Iranian media .

Three experts told Bellingcat the munitions appeared to be air-delivered US-made Gator anti-tank mines.

The US is the only participant in the Iran war known to possess Gator Scatterable Mines.

Bellingcat asked the US Department of Defense whether it had dropped the mines overnight, but did not receive a response at time of publication.

Satellite Imagery showing the village where the mines were found in relation to an Iranian “missile city”. Source: Logan Williams / Bellingcat. Aerial imagery © 2026 Airbus, CNES / Airbus, Landsat / Copernicus, Maxar Technologies via Google Earth. Inset map © 2026 Mapcreator, OpenStreetMap.

Dr NR Jenzen-Jones, Director of Armament Research Services, told Bellingcat that the images appeared to show US-made anti-tank landmines.

“These images show what appear to be American BLU-91/B scatterable anti-tank landmines.

“The BLU-91/B is dispensed from the CBU-78/B or CBU-89/B air-delivered cargo bombs (cluster munitions).

“The presence of square ‘aeroballistic adaptors’ indicates that the mines seen here were delivered by air. Similar mines can be dispensed from the vehicle- or helicopter-based Volcano system.”

Gator “SCATMINE” system. BLU-91/B pictured on the bottom left, BLU-92/B pictured on the bottom right. Source: Department of the Army .

Amael Kotlarski, Weapons Team leader at Janes, also identified the mines as BLU-91/B ‘Gator’ anti-tank mines. Kotlarski told Bellingcat “the BLU-91/B is dispensed from either the US Air Force’s CBU-89/B (72 BLU-91/B and 22 BLU-92/B) or the US Navy’s CBU-78/B (45 BLU-91/B and 15 BLU-92/B).”

He elaborated that the BLU-92/B is an anti-personnel mine, similar in appearance to a BLU-91/B, though not identical.

“No BLU-92/B is observable in the photographic evidence presented so far. This could be that they have not been found, or that the dispensers were loaded solely with AT mines to help reduce the risk to civilians.”

The Gator system is an air-delivered dispenser system or cargo bomb that distributes mines over an area. These dispensers contain a mixture of either 94 or 60 BLU-92/B

anti-personnel and BLU-91/B anti-vehicle mines depending on which dispenser is used. These dispensers release the mines over an area of approximately 200 by 650 metres . In the images reviewed by Bellingcat, it is not clear which dispenser was used, or how many dispensers were deployed.

Reference images of the BLU-92/B and BLU-91/B. These mines may or may not have the box-shaped “aeroballistic adaptor” attached to the circular mine when found. Source: Naval Explosive Ordnance Technology Division via Bullet-picker .

Andro Mathewson, an independent open source analyst, who formerly worked at landmine-clearing NGO The HALO Trust, told Bellingcat the images showed BLU-91/B mines.

BLU-91/B mine found with an aeroballistic adaptor. Source: Tasnim News .

Some of the images of the mines posted by Iranian media show an aeroballistic adaptor. The aeroballistic adaptor is only present on the BLU-91/B and BLU-92/B, not on other mines within the US Family of Scatterable Mines (FASCAM), indicating that these were deployed from a Gator system aircraft dispenser.

BLU-91/B mine with a partially broken aeroballistic adaptor. Source: Tasnim News .

BLU-91/B and BLU-92/B Mines and Self-Destruct Features

Both BLU-91/B and BLU-92/B mines are activated two minutes after being deployed; however, a very small number can fail to properly arm and explode . These mines also have self-destruct features with a variable delay which means they may randomly explode hours or days after they are dispensed. They may also explode if disturbed. These features make them particularly dangerous.

The self-destruct can be set for 4 hours, 48 hours, or 15 days, but the mines may self-destruct before then .

So far, only visual evidence of magnetically influenced BLU-91/B anti-tank mines has been posted online, but these mines are usually deployed alongside the anti-personnel BLU-92/B. The BLU-92/B also deploys tripwires.

In addition to the self-destruct features, the BLU-92/B anti-personnel mines have an anti-handling device (AHD) that is intended to make the mine explode when disturbed. While BLU-91/B anti-tank mines do not have an anti-handling device (AHD), they “may detonate when moved , because the mine may sense a significant change from its original orientation.”

Amael Kotlarski of Janes told Bellingcat that “The mine will go off if subjected to significant movement.” This could explain local reports that a man was killed when he picked one up near his car.

Federal Cyber Experts Thought Microsoft's Cloud Was "a Pile of Shit." They Approved It Anyway.

Renee Dudley · ProPublica

In late 2024, the federal government's cybersecurity evaluators rendered a troubling verdict on one of Microsoft's biggest cloud computing offerings.

The tech giant's "lack of proper detailed security documentation" left reviewers with a "lack of confidence in assessing the system's overall security posture," according to an internal government report reviewed by ProPublica.

Or, as one member of the team put it: "The package is a pile of shit."

For years, reviewers said, Microsoft had tried and failed to fully explain how it protects sensitive information in the cloud as it hops from server to server across the digital terrain. Given that and other unknowns, government experts couldn't vouch for the technology's security.

Such judgments would be damning for any company seeking to sell its wares to the U. S. government, but it should have been particularly devastating for Microsoft. The tech giant's products had been at the heart of two major cybersecurity attacks against the U. S. in three years. In one, Russian hackers exploited a weakness to steal sensitive data from a number of federal agencies, including the National Nuclear Security Administration. In the other, Chinese hackers infiltrated the email accounts of a Cabinet member and other senior government officials.

The federal government could be further exposed if it couldn't verify the cybersecurity of Microsoft's Government Community Cloud High, a suite of cloud-based services intended to safeguard some of the nation's most sensitive information.

Yet, in a highly unusual move that still reverberates across Washington, the Federal Risk and Authorization Management Program, or FedRAMP, authorized the product anyway, bestowing what amounts to the federal government's cybersecurity seal of approval. FedRAMP's ruling — which included a kind of "buyer beware" notice to any federal agency considering GCC High — helped Microsoft expand a government business empire worth billions of dollars.

"BOOM SHAKA LAKA," Richard Wakeman, one of the company's chief security architects, boasted in an online forum, celebrating the milestone with a meme of Leonardo DiCaprio in "The Wolf of Wall Street." Wakeman did not respond to requests for comment.

It was not the type of outcome that federal policymakers envisioned a decade and a half ago when they embraced the cloud revolution and created FedRAMP to help safeguard the government's cybersecurity. The program's layers of review, which included an assessment by outside experts, were supposed to ensure that service providers like Mi-

crosoft could be entrusted with the government's secrets. But ProPublica's investigation — drawn from internal FedRAMP memos, logs, emails, meeting minutes, and interviews with seven former and current government employees and contractors — found breakdowns at every juncture of that process. It also found a remarkable deference to Microsoft, even as the company's products and practices were central to two of the most damaging cyberattacks ever carried out against the government.

This is not security. This is security theater.

Tony Sager, former NSA computer scientist

FedRAMP first raised questions about GCC High's security in 2020 and asked Microsoft to provide detailed diagrams explaining its encryption practices. But when the company produced what FedRAMP considered to be only partial information in fits and starts, program officials did not reject Microsoft's application. Instead, they repeatedly pulled punches and allowed the review to drag out for the better part of five years. And because federal agencies were allowed to deploy the product during the review, GCC High spread across the government as well as the defense industry. By late 2024, FedRAMP reviewers concluded that they had little choice but to authorize the technology — not because their questions had been answered or their review was complete, but largely on the grounds that Microsoft's product was already being used across Washington.

Today, key parts of the federal government, including the Justice and Energy departments, and the defense sector rely on this technology to protect highly sensitive information that, if leaked, "could be expected to have a severe or catastrophic adverse effect" on operations, assets and individuals, the government has said.

"This is not a happy story in terms of the security of the U. S.," said Tony Sager, who spent more than three decades as a computer scientist at the National Security Agency and now is an executive at the nonprofit Center for Internet Security.

For years, the FedRAMP process has been equated with actual security, Sager said. ProPublica's findings, he said, shatter that facade.

"This is not security," he said. "This is security theater."

Despite a "lack of confidence in assessing" the security of Microsoft's GCC High, FedRAMP authorized the product anyway. Alex Wong/Getty Images

ProPublica is exposing the government's reservations about this popular product for the first time. We are also revealing Microsoft's yearslong inability to provide the encryption documentation and evidence the federal reviewers sought.

The revelations come as the Justice Department ramps up scrutiny of the government's technology contractors. In December, the department announced the indictment of a

As Trump Demands Voter Data, This Fiercely Independent Red State Says No

Audrey Dutton · ProPublica

States were on notice from the U. S. Department of Justice that if they didn't fall in line, the federal government would force them into compliance.

It wasn't President Donald Trump's administration applying pressure. It was the early 1990s, and President Bill Clinton had signed the "motor voter" law requiring states to offer voter registration when someone applies for a driver's license.

Idaho, with its fiercely independent streak, didn't want to participate. So instead of going along with the federal government's new National Voter Registration Act, state legislators followed the recommendation of Idaho's top election officials and scrambled for a way out. Because the federal voter law said states with same-day voter registration could be exempt, Idaho lawmakers passed a bill almost unanimously, with full support from Republicans, to adopt same-day registration.

Idaho's chief deputy secretary of state at the time, Ben Ysursa, described the move as an almost existential response to "an insidious federal intrusion into state election procedures."

The Clinton Justice Department eventually sued three states for not complying with its demands. By then, Idaho's had a shield against litigation due to its exemption.

Three decades later, the exemption and the philosophy that led to it are at the heart of Idaho's refusal to comply with a very different demand by the Trump Justice Department. The state's top election official cites the exemption as one reason he will not sign a deal to give the Trump administration all the voter data his office holds, including sensitive personal information like partial Social Security and driver's license numbers.

Idaho Secretary of State Phil McGrane is one of about a dozen Republicans nationally to resist the administration's efforts to gather sensitive voter data ahead of the 2026 midterm elections, in the face of litigation threats from the Justice Department.

In a state that Trump won in 2024 by one of the largest margins in the country, an effort that the administration touts as essential to weeding out noncitizen voters has tested the limits of what a committed Trump stronghold will tolerate when it comes to privacy and federal power.

Lists of voter addresses and party affiliations are often available to the public through an open records request. McGrane provided the government with this version. But state election administrators also keep more sensitive information such as a person's exact date of birth and partial Social Security number. In Idaho, the law says this information can't be given out — and that's what the Trump administration is still after.

Among the other five states exempt from the law, three have refused to give up their voters' sensitive information and have since been sued by the Justice Department. Wyoming handed over its data without a lawsuit. Other states that are not exempt have also been sued.

McGrane, who is an attorney, told the Justice Department in letters that he doesn't see any legal reason why he should honor the government's request — and that, given the administration's recent admissions over its handling of sensitive data, he couldn't be sure the department would keep it safe, which is his duty under state law.

The trimmed-down version of voter info he'd already handed over should be enough for "any legitimate inquiry" by the government into how effectively Idaho maintains its voter lists, McGrane wrote.

Through a spokesperson, McGrane declined an interview request from ProPublica, citing the possibility of an impending lawsuit from the Justice Department. A spokesperson for the Justice Department also declined to comment.

Idaho's Republican secretary of state, Phil McGrane, is one of about a dozen Republicans nationally to resist the administration's efforts to gather sensitive voter data ahead of the 2026 midterm elections. Kyle Green/AP Photo

A Justice Department attorney threatened to sue Idaho in December, in a halting voicemail with McGrane's office that was obtained by ProPublica and previously reported on by the Idaho Capital Sun.

"I need to get some clarification as to what you're going to be doing. Or not doing. So, again, I need a response from you," the lawyer says in the recording. "You may have seen in the news that we have sued six states earlier this week for refusing to provide their voter registration lists, and we're preparing additional lawsuits."

The lawyer then tells the secretary of state's office he would "like to keep everyone out of that as possible — as much as possible, but I haven't heard anything back from you."

Ysursa, who served three terms as secretary of state until 2015, said McGrane is "in a much more politically volatile situation than I ever was."

"Going against Trump in Idaho on certain things, that's a fine line," Ysursa said. "And I think he's doing a good job. He's doing the right thing."

Public policy surveys in Idaho conducted since the 1990s have surfaced a current of "distrust or wariness towards federal control or national control," said Matthew May, survey research director at the Boise State University School of Public Service.

The polling over time has revealed Idahoans' strong belief in independence, May said.

Apple Now Requires Device-Level Age Verification in the UK. Could the US Be Next?

EditorDavid · Slashdot

Apple unveiled new device-level age restrictions in the UK on Wednesday. “After downloading a new update, users will now have to confirm that they are 18 or older to access unrestricted features,” reports Gizmodo.

“Users will be able to confirm their age with a credit card or by scanning an ID.”

For those underage or who have not confirmed their age, Apple will turn on Web Content Filter and Communication Safety, which will not only restrict access to certain apps or websites, but will also monitor messages, shared photo albums, AirDrop, and FaceTime calls for nudity. Apple didn’t specify exactly which services and features are banned for under-18 users, but it will likely be in compliance with UK legislation...

The British government does not require Apple and other OS providers to institute device-level age checks, but it does restrict minor access to online pornography under the Online Safety Act, which passed in 2023. So far, that restriction has only been implemented at the website level, but UK officials have been worried about easy loopholes to evade the age restrictions, like VPNs.

The broader tech industry has been campaigning for some time to use device-level age checks instead in response to the rising tide of under-16 social media and internet bans around the world. Last month, in a landmark social media trial

in California, Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg also supported this idea, saying that conducting age verification “at the level of the phone is just a lot clearer than having every single app out there have to do this separately.” Pornhub-operator Aylo had advocated for device-level restrictions in the UK as well, and even sent out letters to Apple, Google, and Microsoft in November asking for OS-level age verification...

The most obvious question: Could this be brought state-side?

Read more of this story at [Slashdot](#).

Video Shows US Tomahawk Missile Strike Next to Girls’ School in Iran

Trevor Ball · Bellingcat

New video footage shows a US Tomahawk missile hitting an Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) facility in Minab, Iran, on Feb 28, showing for the first time that the US struck the area.

The footage, released by Mehr News and geolocated by Bellingcat, also shows smoke already rising from the vicinity of the girls’ school where 175 people were reportedly killed, including children.

New video footage shows a US Tomahawk missile hitting an IRGC facility in Minab, Iran, on Feb 28, showing for the first time that the US struck the area. The footage also shows smoke already rising from the vicinity of the girls’ school, where 175 people were reportedly killed. pic.twitter.com/4jBXrNcRJO

— Trevor Ball (@Easybakeovensz) March 8, 2026

The footage would appear to contradict US President Donald Trump’s claim that it was an Iranian missile that hit the school.

Left: Image showing a Tomahawk missile from the airstrike in Minab. Right: A Tomahawk missile flying over Tehran earlier in the conflict.

The US is the only participant in the war that is known to have Tomahawk missiles. Israel is not known to have Tomahawk missiles.

The red cone superimposed over this image shows the estimated area of

impact of the missile visible in the footage. The graphic also shows the position of a clinic, the school and other damaged buildings.

Planet Labs satellite imagery shows that only two structures within this red cone were damaged, including a clinic.

The other structure appears to be an earth-covered magazine or bunker.

Imagery showing two damaged structures. Source: PlanetLabs.

Giancarlo Fiorella and Merel Zoet contributed research to this piece.

The post Video Shows US Tomahawk Missile Strike Next to Girls’ School in Iran appeared first on [bellingcat](#).

So far, that restriction has only been implemented at the website level, but UK officials have been worried about easy loopholes to evade the age restrictions, like VPNs.

EditorDavid

BRIEFS

IN BRIEF

The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity): Cybersecurity researchers have disclosed three security vulnerabilities impacting LangChain and LangGraph that, if successfully exploited, could expose filesystem data, environment secrets, and conversation history. Both LangChain and LangGraph are open-source frameworks that are used to build applications powered by Large Language Models (LLMs). LangGraph is built on the foundations of

The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity): Most teams have security tools in place. Alerts are firing, dashboards look clean, threat intel is flowing in. On the surface, everything feels under control. But one question usually stays unanswered: Would your defenses actually stop a real attack? That's where things get shaky. A control exists, so it's assumed to work. A detection rule is active, so it's expected to catch something. But very

Madeleine Schwartz, Dissent Magazine: Anne Hidalgo's mayoralty illustrates the limits of local responses to national and international problems like housing and climate change. Without wider coordination, even the most successful mayor's reach can only extend so far.

The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity): Cybersecurity researchers have uncovered malicious artifacts distributed via Docker Hub following the Trivy supply chain attack, highlighting the widening blast radius across developer environments. The last known clean release of Trivy on Docker Hub is 0.69.3. The malicious versions 0.69.4, 0.69.5, and 0.69.6 have since been removed from the container image library. "New image tags 0.69.5 and

The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity): Cybersecurity researchers have disclosed a vulnerability in Anthropic's Claude Google Chrome Extension that could have been exploited to trigger malicious prompts simply by visiting a web page. The flaw "allowed any website to silently inject prompts into that assistant as if the user wrote them," Koi Security researcher Oren Yomtov said in a report shared with The Hacker News. "No clicks, no

John R. Puri, National Review: A coastguard boat approaches an Indian liquefied petroleum gas carrier as it arrives at Mundra Port via the Strait of Hormuz, amid the U. S.-Israel conflict with Iran, in Gujarat, India, March 16, 2026.

The Hacker News, The Hacker News (cybersecurity): Oracle has released security updates to address a critical security flaw impacting Identity Manager and Web Services Manager that could be exploited to achieve remote code execution. The vulnerability, tracked as CVE-2026-21992, carries a CVSS score of 9.8 out of a maximum of 10.0. "This vulnerability is remotely exploitable without authentication," Oracle said in an advisory. "If successfully

Matthew Sitman and Sam Adler-Bell, Dissent Magazine: Matt and Sam are joined by Know Your Enemy's intrepid producer, Jesse Brenneman, to discuss the recent film One Battle After Another .

Al Jazeera English, Al Jazeera English: As troops push towards Litani River, mourners gather for the funeral of three slain journalists killed in line of duty.

Alexander Hertel-Fernandez, Dissent Magazine: Labor unions have long been central to the fight for democracy. But they can only play that role when members are engaged and trust their unions to fight for them.

That fix required parsing the source code during execution.

Ned Batchelder

Southern Register

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